

Who Is Likely to Leave — And What We Can Do About It

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The Bottom Line

About 16% of our employees leave each year. Using their HR records — role, pay, overtime, travel, tenure, and satisfaction scores — we built a tool that can flag, in advance, which employees are at higher risk of leaving. In testing, it correctly identified 2 out of every 3 people who actually left, before they left.

What Drives People to Leave

- **Overtime is the single biggest warning sign.** Employees regularly working overtime are far more likely to leave than anyone else in the data.
- **Frequent travel is the second biggest factor.** Employees who travel often for work show notably higher exit rates.
- **Pay matters, but it's not the main story.** Employees who left earned about 30% less on average than those who stayed — but salary ranked below overtime and travel in predicting who actually leaves. Workload and lifestyle strain appear to matter just as much as the paycheck.
- **The first year is the danger zone.** 35% of employees leave within their first year, dropping to just 8% for employees who've been here 10+ years. If someone makes it past year one, they are far more likely to stay long-term.

Where to Focus First

Sales — and Sales Representatives specifically — should be the top retention priority. Nearly 4 in 10 Sales Representatives leave, more than double the rate of any other role in the company. Lab Technicians and HR staff also show elevated exit rates worth watching.

Two Recommendations We Can Act On Now

- **1. Review overtime load in Sales.** Identify Sales Representatives currently logging sustained overtime and have their managers proactively check in — this is the single highest-risk combination we found in the data.
- **2. Build a structured first-year check-in program.** Since exits are concentrated in year one, a simple 30/60/90-day check-in process could catch problems early, before someone decides to leave.

An Honest Limitation

This tool is a warning signal, not a verdict. It will sometimes flag someone as "at risk" who was actually going to stay — in our test, that happened for roughly 1 in 5 employees we predicted would leave. The right way to use this is to prioritize retention conversations, not to make decisions about any one person based on the model alone.